The Shared Tradition of I Cor. 4:10-13 and Mat. 5:3-12

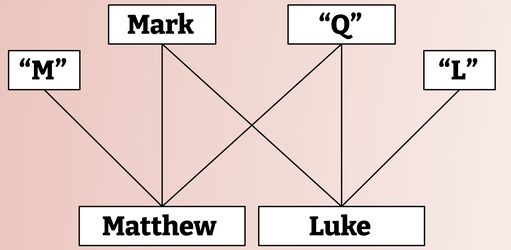
Marcus Larsen, Karl Kuhn, Ph.D.

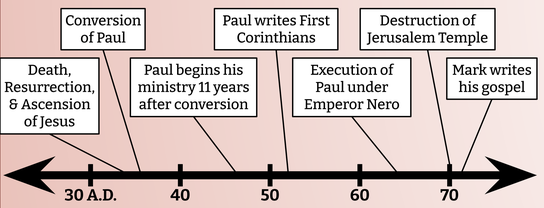
The Synoptic Problem

The traditions of Jesus predate the written testimony of the Gospels. Such traditions were likely collections of Jesus' sayings and other instructive narrative segments of Jesus' life.

The gospel writers used the traditions of Jesus in their biographies of Jesus' life. Mark is often regarded as the first gospel that was written because ~97% of Mark can be found in Matthew and Luke. Thus, Matt. and Luke probably used Mark as a source. Although they contain much unique material, Matt. and Luke also share a lot of material that is not found in Mark. Scholars believe this shared material may come from a hypothetical source called "Q." Likewise, content that is unique to Matt. and Luke are said to come from the hypothetical sources "M" and "L" respectively.

Four Source Hypothesis





Major events during the development of New Testament traditions

Pauline Rhetoric

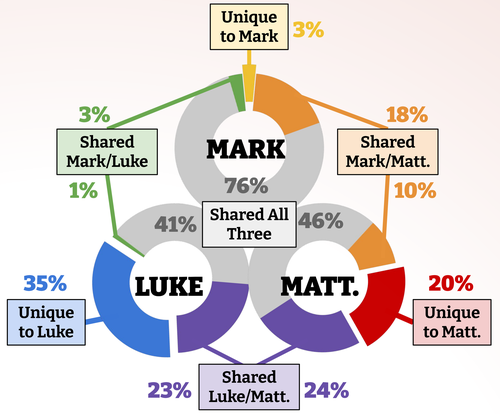
Although Paul was likely not an educated rhetorician, Acts records that he was a skilled orator and his epistles to Corinth had a known emotional impact on the Corinthians (II Cor. 10:9-11). Paul uses certain rhetorical devices in his epistles. In I Cor. 4, Paul exhorts the boastfulness of the church in Corinth. The height of this exhortation (vv. 1-13) uses chiasm, irony, sarcasm, and synkrisis (comparison) to amplify the bad qualities of the Corinthians. Part of Paul's exhortation (vv. 10-13) is similar in structure, content, and purpose to Jesus' beatitudes.

If Paul is intentionally borrowing from Jesus' sayings as an appeal to authority, it would demonstrate that the Corinthians were already familiar with this part of the Jesus tradition and understood the sayings of Jesus recorded in this tradition to be authoritative.

Implications

This shared tradition is a possible indications of the originality of the Matthean form of the beatitudes, which also possibly confirms that Matthew predates Luke. Further research would have to be done finding shared Matthean/Lukan material in pre-synoptic sources (like Paul) and examining how Matt. and/or Luke redact the material

This could also confirm that Paul's familiarity with the Jesus tradition. If so, it is possible that Paul was catechized with the Jesus tradition during his conversion. Further research could be done finding other places where Paul borrows from the known set of Jesus traditions.



The Beatitudes

Jesus' beatitudes appear in Matt. (Mt. 5:3-12) and Luke (Lk. 6:20-26) in the sermons on the mount and plain respectively. If Paul's "beatitudes" in I Cor. 4 were based in Jesus' sayings, it seems that they are most similar to Matt. This might signal that Matt. is borrowing from a more original source of the Jesus tradition and that Luke is changes it. In light of the fact that reversal is a central theme in Luke's gospel, Luke may have redacted the beatitude tradition to more appropriately fit his gospel.

Because Paul's letters predate the gospels, a Pauline use of the Matthean form of the beatitudes might show that Matt.'s source for the beatitudes predates Luke's. This may also signal the development of the Jesus tradition.

	Jesus (Matthew 5:3-12)	**Paul** (I Corinthians 4:10-13)
1	Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.	We are fools for the sake of Christ, but you are wise in Christ.
2	Blessed are those who mourn, for they will be comforted.	We are weak, but you are strong.
3	Blessed are the meek, for they will inherit the earth.	You are held in honor, but we in disrepute.
4	Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they will be filled.	To the present hour we are hungry and thirsty,
5	Blessed are the merciful, for they will receive mercy.	We are poorly clothed and beaten and homeless,
6	Blessed are the pure in heart, for they will see God.	And we grow weary from the work of our own hands.
7	Blessed are the peacemakers, for they will be called children of God.	When reviled, we bless;
8	Blessed are those who are persecuted for righteousness' sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.	When persecuted, we endure;
9	Blessed are you when people revile you and persecute you and utter all kinds of evil against you falsely on my account.	We have become like the rubbish of the world, the dregs of all things, to this very day.
10	Rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven, for in the same way they persecuted the prophets who were before you.	Then each one will receive commendation from God. (4:5)

References

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